Why the BJP Says It Is Not a Right-wing Party

The day Narendra Modi won his second term on 23 May 2019, he made only one big economic assertion in his victory speech, which was telecast live from the BJP headquarters in Delhi. He argued there are only two castes of people now in India. 'There is one caste in India of people who are poor,' he said, 'and another caste of those who are trying to help make the country free of poverty. There are those who want to come out of poverty and then there are those who want to free the nation of poverty. These are the only two castes in the country and we must strengthen these both in the twenty-first century.'[42] Ideationally, this political articulation on removing poverty as a national goal was closer to Indira Gandhi's election-winning slogan of 'Garibi Hatao' (Eradicate Poverty) from 1971 than many would expect from a right-wing government.

When he was first elected in 2014 on a slogan of 'Acche Din' (Good Days) and 'Minimum Government, Maximum Governance', many in India's middle classes switched support because they saw him as a pro-market, epoch-defining economic reformer, like Margaret Thatcher in the United Kingdom or Ronald Reagan in the United States. The author Gurcharan Das, for example, argued in *Financial Times* that this could be India's 'Thatcher moment'. 'I have never voted for the BJP,' he wrote, but 'chose Mr Modi because he is India's best chance to restore economic growth and reward us with a "demographic dividend"'.[43] For the world's press, looking to understand the kind of leader Modi would be, Reagan and Thatcher were the most common economic comparison at the time.[44] There were those among his opponents who described him as being closer to Vladimir Putin,[45] but the most widely held assumption was that, in economic terms at least, this was a reformist leader who would be 'pro-business', 'right-wing' and a huge break from the past—one under whose watch India would embark on the next stage of economic reforms. Of course, definitions of what constitutes 'right-wing' and 'left-wing' politics have evolved over time and may elude neat classifications, but the BJP was expected by many, as a 'right-wing' party, to be more supportive of free markets, privatisation and deregulation.